

PROOF OF CONCEPT

Vitsika

Malagasy ant identification from a single photograph

vitsika is Malagasy for ant. Genus-level, 27 genera, built on public data and a frozen public model.

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VitsikaMalagasy ant genus identification · proof of concept

IdentifyGeneraDistributionAtlasMethods

← Identify another specimen

QUERY IMAGE



casent0002219_p.jpg · embedded in 1240 ms

GENUS PREDICTION

Royidris 100%
subfamily myrmicinae

✓ Held-out test specimen casent0002219 (AntWeb label: *Royidris notorthotenes*) · correct

1. *Royidris* myrmicinae 99.7%

2. *Nesomyrmex* myrmicinae 0.2%

3. *Pheidole* myrmicinae 0.1%

See where this lands on the atlas →

Where *Royidris* has been collected →

← Identify another specimen

hf-hub:imageomics/bloclip-2 · probe 2026-08-30 · probabilities calibrated on cross-validated training folds (temperature scaling, 5 folds); still an answer among the 27 genera only.

Most similar training specimens

cosine similarity of BloCLIP 2 embeddings; species labels are AntWeb's, not the model's



Royidris notorthotenes
myrmicinae
casent0002259 0.950
© April Nobile · [AntWeb](#)



Royidris robertsoni
myrmicinae
casent0077935 0.981
© April Nobile · [AntWeb](#)



Royidris notorthotenes
myrmicinae
casent0002257 0.889
© April Nobile · [AntWeb](#)



Monomorium bifidoclypeatum
myrmicinae
casent0173589 0.861
© April Nobile · [AntWeb](#)



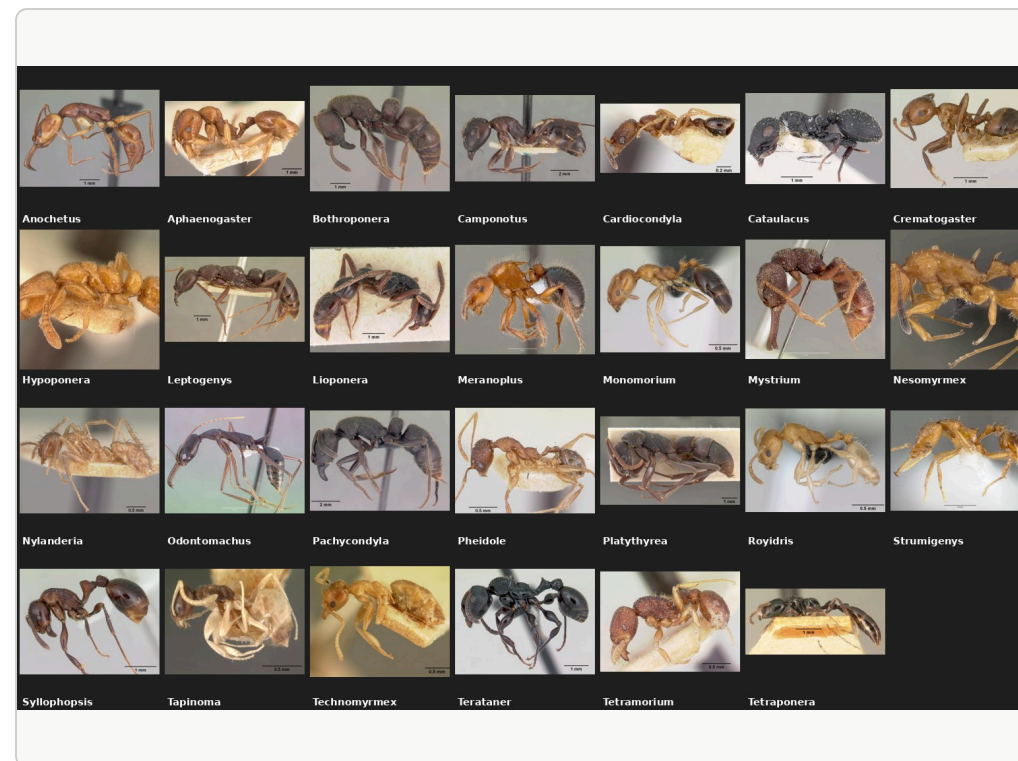
Nesomyrmex flavus
myrmicinae
casent0189276 0.858
© Erin Prado · [AntWeb](#)

Vitsika: *vitsika* is Malagasy for ant. Images © their photographers via [AntWeb](#) (CC BY-SA); metadata via GBIF (CC BY).

[Methods & limitations](#)

Genus-level identification is scarce expertise - a local first pass multiplies it

- AntWeb's GBIF dataset held **141,430** Malagasy ant records on 2026-08-26, **6,995** with images, across **60** imaged genera (GBIF occurrence API; doi:10.15468/wqmjjt). Naming even the genus takes a specialist and a microscope.
- Three decades of collecting, imaging and determination by the California Academy of Sciences and Malagasy field teams make this data trainable at all. MBC's Phase III roadmap: "with training, more steps can be done in Madagascar" (madagascarbio.org/monitoring.html).
- Vitsika demonstrates the complement: a photo-to-genus triage running in **~0.8 s** on a CPU in Antananarivo, so local teams handle the routine cases and specialists' time goes to the hard and the new.



One AntWeb profile shot per genus in scope (27). Sources: reports/01_explore.txt, README.md.

From GBIF to 1,236 clean images in 27 genera



Finding 1: GBIF's image cache is empty for AntWeb

4,215 of 4,354 cache requests returned 404 (96.8 %), uniformly across years and record age. antweb.org blocks scripts (Cloudflare) and datacenter IPs (403), including GBIF's own fetcher. The working source is the 2008-2014 bulk upload to Wikimedia Commons (33,081 files), matched by specimen code.

Finding 2: caste is not in GBIF's interpreted fields

GBIF maps sex to Male / Female / Other, so every worker arrives as null: 4,540 of 5,857 specimens. The caste has to be read from the verbatim record (dwc:sex): 4,539 workers, 673 queens, 640 males, and only workers are kept.

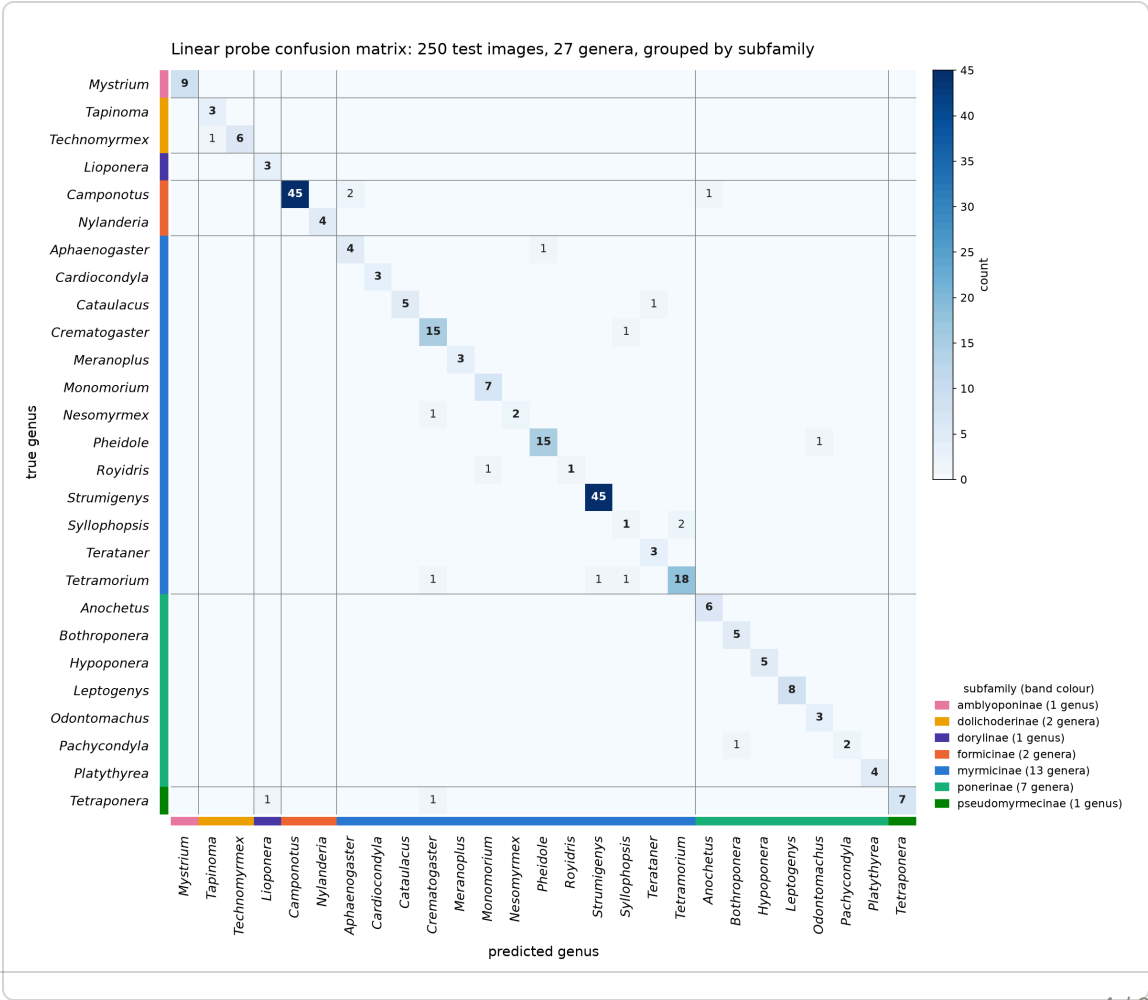
RESULTS

Linear probe on frozen BioCLIP 2 embeddings: 92.8 % top-1 on 250 held-out specimens

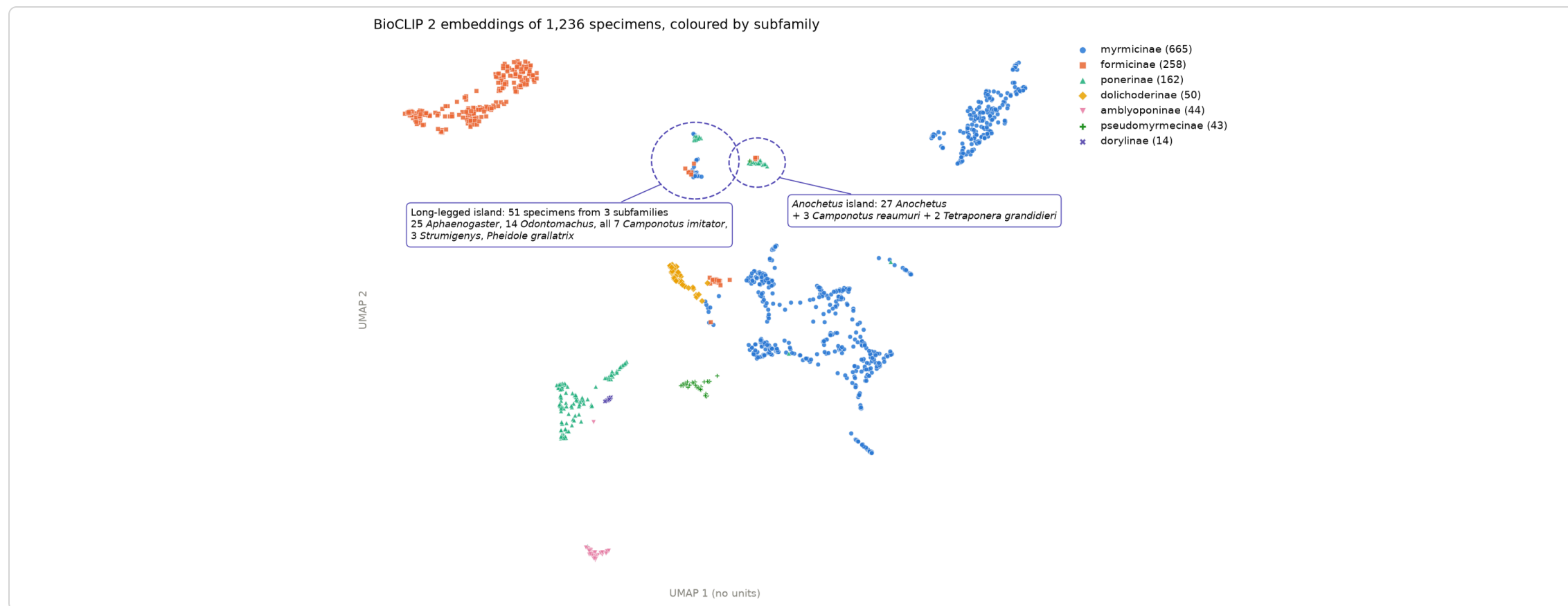
METHOD	TOP - 1	TOP - 3	MACRO - F1
Zero-shot, "a photo of {genus}, a genus of ant"	74.4 %	94.0 %	0.590
Linear probe (deployed)	92.8 %	98.4 %	0.885
Nearest neighbour, cosine	91.6 %	93.2 %	0.834

986 train / 250 test, 27 genera, split grouped by specimen, stratified by genus (seed 42). Bare genus name as the zero-shot prompt: 32.8 % top-1. Embeddings: imageomics/bioclclip-2 ViT-L/14, 768-d, no fine-tuning.

18 errors: 12 genuine look-alikes or species unseen in training (*Sylophopsis* vs *Tetramorium*, *Royidris* vs *Monomorium*), 3 poor photos, 2 odd angles, 1 unexplained. Almost every confusion stays inside a subfamily block.



The embedding space recapitulates taxonomy, with body-plan islands



Subfamilies form clean clusters; where the model "errs", it groups *Camponotus imitator* with long-legged *Aphaenogaster* and *Odontomachus*, a resemblance a taxonomist would recognise, not noise.

Three things this codebase already supports

1

Complete the image set

70.2 % of the manifest's images are missing. `05_download_antweb.py` + `dataset_full.csv` are ready for a residential IP or an AntWeb bulk export; re-thresholding brings *Vitsika*, *Tanipone*, *Carebara* and 9 more genera into scope (39 in total).

2

Species-grouped split and an open-set reject

Group the split by species (one flag in `03_build_dataset.py`) and turn the nearest-neighbour similarity the API already returns into a "none of the 27" reject (probability calibration: done, live since 2026-08-30).

3

Multi-view, multi-caste embeddings

The harvest already holds 6,634 head and 5,127 dorsal media rows plus 673 queens and 640 males; `config.yaml` (`views_priority`, `castes`) and `06_embed.py` make view-wise embedding and late fusion a configuration change.